



The Papyrus Handbook

A guide to Markdown books with Papyrus

milon/papyrus

The Papyrus Handbook

Markdown to PDF, EPUB, HTML sites, and KDP

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Welcome

Thanks for opening **The Papyrus Handbook**. Use the sidebar to browse chapters, or continue from Introduction. The home page has the project banner, a **Downloads** link for PDF previews from GitHub, and links to GitHub and Packagist.

This guide is the companion for [milon/papyrus](https://github.com/milon/papyrus) — a PHP CLI that turns Markdown into PDF, EPUB, HTML, a multi-page site, and Amazon KDP exports. You are reading those same chapters as a Papyrus site.

How to use this guide

1. **Introduction** — what Papyrus is and the project layout
2. **Install** — Composer setup and `papyrus init`
3. **Configuration** — every `papyrus.php` option
4. **Writing** — Markdown, front matter (`pretoc`, `draft`), asides, Mermaid, linting
5. **Themes** — PDF / HTML themes and fonts
6. **build** — all-in-one export, watch, caches
7. **build:pdf / epub / html / site / sample** — one chapter each (`serve` is covered with site)
8. **kdp** and **kdp:*** — Kindle, print, covers, metadata, package
9. **Migration and CI** — ibis-next migration and GitHub Actions
10. **Command reference** — full CLI tables
11. **Downloads** — light and dark PDF previews from GitHub

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build:html

Build a **single-file** HTML book with light / dark mode.

```
papyrus build:html  
papyrus build:html -d /path/to/book -e docs
```

Options

Option	Short	Default	Meaning
<code>--dir</code>	<code>-d</code>	current directory	Book root
<code>--export</code>	<code>-e</code>	<code>export/</code>	Output directory

Output

```
export/<slug>.html
```

Requires `theme-html.html` (project `assets/` or bundled default).

Placeholders in the theme:

Placeholder	Source
<code>{{ \$title }}</code>	<code>title</code>
<code>{{ \$subtitle }}</code>	<code>subtitle</code>
<code>{{ \$author }}</code>	<code>author</code>
<code>{{ \$body }}</code>	Rendered chapters

The default stub theme mirrors the light PDF palette, with a moon/sun toggle that switches to the dark PDF colours. The reading column follows Tailwind screen widths (640 → 1536px).

`@font-face` rules that point at `../assets/fonts/` are embedded as base64 data URIs at build time, so the single HTML file is self-contained even when fonts come from Papyrus's bundled defaults.

Config that affects HTML

Key	Role
<code>title</code> , <code>subtitle</code> , <code>author</code>	Document chrome
<code>mermaid</code>	Figures; <code>theme</code> $\Rightarrow$ <code>auto</code> embeds light + dark SVGs
<code>fonts</code>	Loaded via the HTML theme's <code>@font-face</code> rules

Site vs HTML

Command	Result
<code>build:html</code>	One self-contained <code>.html</code> file
<code>build:site</code>	Multi-page folder with sidebar, Home, shared CSS/JS

Use `build:html` for emailing or archiving a single document; use `build:site` for hosting.

kdp:cover

Copy configured cover images from **assets/** into **export/** with KDP-oriented filenames. No enable flag — safe to run anytime.

```
papyrus kdp:cover
papyrus kdp:cover -d /path/to/book -e /path/to/out
papyrus kdp:cover --dimensions --pages=220
papyrus kdp:cover --wrap --pages=220
papyrus kdp:cover --wrap --theme=light
```

Options

Option	Short	Default	Meaning
<code>--dir</code>	<code>-d</code>	current directory	Book root
<code>--export</code>	<code>-e</code>	<code>export/</code>	Output directory
<code>--dimensions</code>		off	Print wrap-cover size estimate (spine + full bleed)
<code>--wrap</code>		off	Generate wraparound cover PDF + PNG preview
<code>--pages</code>		from print PDF	Page count for <code>--dimensions</code> / <code>--wrap</code>
<code>--theme</code>		first theme	Front-cover theme used by <code>--wrap</code>

Sources and outputs

Source	Export name
<code>kdp.ebook.cover</code> → <code>assets/<file></code>	<code><slug>-kdp-ebook-cover.<ext></code>
<code>cover[<theme>]</code> or <code>cover.image</code>	<code><slug>-kdp-print-cover-<theme>.<ext></code> (one per theme)

Missing source files are skipped (no error). If nothing is copied, the command still succeeds with a comment.

Example

```
'cover' => [
  'image' => 'cover.png',
  'light' => 'cover-light.png',
],
'kdp' => [
  'ebook' => [
    'cover' => 'cover-ebook.jpg',
  ],
],
```

With themes **light** and **dark**, a typical export folder might contain:

```
export/my-book-kdp-ebook-cover.jpg
export/my-book-kdp-print-cover-light.png
export/my-book-kdp-print-cover-dark.png    # if dark cover
resolves
```

Papyrus copies files as-is for ebook/front covers. With **--wrap** it also composes a **paperback wraparound** PDF (back | spine | front, plus bleed) using Amazon's spine formula and your front cover image:

```
papyrus kdp:cover --wrap
papyrus kdp:cover --wrap --pages=220
```

Outputs:

```
export/<slug>-kdp-print-wrap.pdf # upload to KDP as the cover
export/<slug>-kdp-print-wrap.png # preview
```

Optional config:

```
'cover' => [
  'image' => 'cover.png',
  'back' => 'back-cover.png', // optional; otherwise a text
back panel is drawn
],
'kdp' => [
  'print' => [
    'paper' => 'white', // or cream - affects spine
width
    'back_cover' => 'back-cover.png', // preferred over
cover.back
    'spine_color' => '#1a1a1a', // optional; default
samples the front cover
  ],
],
```

Without `--pages`, Papyrus counts pages in `export/<slug>-kdp-print.pdf` (build `kdp:print` first). Spine text is drawn only when Amazon allows it (≥ 79 pages). Always verify with Amazon's cover calculator before upload.

This is a sample from The Papyrus Handbook —

<https://github.com/milon/papyrus>